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Writing Sample
Position Statement: AB 2053: The Social Housing Act

Executive Summary

To Assembly Member Rebecca Bauer-Kahan: It is undeniable that California is facing a housing crisis of unprecedented scale. With the cost of living skyrocketing and an ever-growing unhoused population, urgent action is required to ensure that all Californians have access to safe, stable, and affordable housing.

I strongly urge your sponsorship and reintroduction of **AB 2053, the Social Housing Act**, a bill that seeks to establish the **California Housing Authority (CHA)**—an independent state entity responsible for constructing new housing developments across the state. These housing units would be leased or sold to residents at rates ensuring that no household pays more than 30% of its monthly income on housing.

This proposal is not just about building more housing; it is about redefining how California approaches affordability, equity, and sustainability in the housing market. AB 2053 represents a long-term investment in **mixed-income, self-sustaining housing** that promotes economic mobility, reduces homelessness, and strengthens California's communities.

By championing this bill, you will be instrumental in addressing one of the most pressing socio-economic issues of our time, helping to create a **sustainable and equitable housing model** that benefits **all Californians**, especially communities that have been historically marginalized.

Problem Statement

How should California address its severe housing shortage while ensuring that low- and middle-income residents can afford to live in their own communities?

Background

California's housing crisis is driven by a **fundamental mismatch** between **housing supply and demand**. According to **Up for Growth**, a nonpartisan housing policy group, the U.S. faces a housing shortage of **3.8 million units**, nearly **one million of which are in California** alone. This supply-demand gap has led to soaring home prices and rental costs, pricing out working-class and middle-class residents.

- The **median home price** in California stands at **\$729,000**, nearly **twice** the national average.
- Average **rents** in major cities are prohibitively high: **\$3,313 in San Francisco** and **\$2,781 in Los Angeles**.
- Between **2010 and 2020**, California permitted just **one new home for every 2.54 jobs added**, exacerbating the housing crunch.

Despite various government efforts—such as **streamlining zoning laws, funding low-income housing, and relaxing certain regulations**—California continues to fall short in meeting housing demand. Many of these policies fail to **scale housing production adequately**, leading to continued price inflation and displacement of residents.

Social Housing as a Solution

Social housing, as proposed in AB 2053, is **not the same as traditional public housing**. Instead, it is a **self-sustaining model** that ensures housing affordability **without relying on ongoing government subsidies**. Inspired by successful models in **Vienna, Singapore, and Finland**, social housing operates under **mixed-income principles**, wherein higher-income tenants help subsidize lower-income tenants, thereby ensuring financial viability.

- **Vienna's Model:** Over **60% of Vienna's population** lives in government-owned housing, yet the city has one of the **highest living standards globally**.
- **Sustainability:** Social housing developments integrate **green building practices**, reducing **carbon emissions** and contributing to **climate resilience**.
- **Economic Stability:** By capping rent at **30% of household income**, social housing prevents **housing instability** and fosters **long-term affordability**.

Policy Options Considered

While various policies have attempted to mitigate the housing crisis, many have been ineffective at **scaling affordability**:

1. **Deregulating Permit Processes** – While reducing bureaucratic hurdles can **accelerate development**, it does not guarantee that housing will be **affordable**.
2. **Inclusionary Zoning** – Requiring developers to set aside affordable units in new projects has been useful but does **not scale** to meet California's massive housing shortage.
3. **Expanding Housing Vouchers** – This helps low-income tenants afford market-rate housing, but **does not increase housing supply**, keeping overall costs high.

Recommendation

To meaningfully address the housing crisis, I **strongly recommend** that Assembly Member Bauer-Kahan sponsor and reintroduce **AB 2053, the Social Housing Act**. Unlike previous interventions, social housing offers a **scalable, long-term solution** to California's affordability crisis. By embracing a model that has **proven successful internationally**, California can take a **bold step toward ensuring housing as a fundamental right for all its residents**.

Conclusion

AB 2053 presents a **transformational opportunity** to reshape California's housing landscape. By establishing the **California Housing Authority**, the state can take proactive steps toward a **sustainable, mixed-income housing model** that benefits current and future generations. **Failure to act now** will only exacerbate economic inequality, environmental degradation, and homelessness. **California must lead by example** and implement a housing solution that prioritizes affordability, stability, and inclusivity.

I urge you to **take decisive action** and champion this critical piece of legislation. **A more affordable, equitable California is within reach—AB 2053 is the key to making it a reality.**

Sources Consulted

- California Legislative Information: AB 2053 <https://leginfo.legislature.ca.gov>
- California YIMBY: AB 2053 <https://cayimby.org>
- The Atlantic: California's Housing Crisis <https://www.theatlantic.com>
- Economist Intelligence Unit: Global Liveability Index <https://www.eiu.com>